



Monastery of Geghard

A medieval monastery with chapels and tombs carved into the cliffs of a spectacular gorge



△ **INSIDE A ROCK-CUT CHAMBER**
Dramatic carvings on the walls of the *zhamatoun* are illuminated by sunlight from a decorated aperture in the ceiling.

Geghardavank, the “Monastery of the Spear,” gets its name from one of the relics once housed there—the spear believed to have wounded Christ on the cross. The monastery is situated high on the cliffside of the Azat River gorge in Kotayk, Armenia. It was for several centuries a simple cave temple, until it was developed into a complex of churches and tombs in the 13th century.

Cut into the rock

Within the boundary of a high defensive wall is an imposing church, the Katoghike Chapel. On its western side is a large *gavit*, a square entrance lobby, which is partially carved into the rock. An entrance from the *gavit*

leads into the mountainside to the series of chambers cut into the rock for which Geghard is best known. The complex includes tombs and vestries notable for columns cut from the solid rock. The walls of these chapels and tombs are decorated with elaborate geometric and floral relief carvings and the distinctive Armenian crosses known as *khachkars*. The whole complex represents a high point in medieval Armenian art and architecture.

▷ THE KATOOGHIKE CHAPEL

The main church is in classically Armenian style with a floor plan of an equal-armed cross on a square base. It is topped by a dome on a cylindrical drum.

